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Oscar Peterson

From his recording debut at age 19, Canadian pianist Oscar Peterson has built a career that is unrivaled in the history of jazz. Mr. Peterson's astounding technique and melodic inventiveness have placed him at the forefront of modern jazz pianists. Many of his recording feature the legendary trio with Ray Brown and Barney Kessel (later Herb Ellis and Ed Thigpen). His frequent visits to the recording studio have also yielded wonderful pairings with artists such as Count Basie, Dizzy Gillespie, Louis Armstrong and Fred Astaire. At the urging of Duke Ellington, Oscar has also produced solo piano recordings that are only rivaled by his musical predecessor Art Tatum. Oscar continues to record and perform today, setting the standard for excellence in his field

Oscar Peterson was interviewed in the Caribbean aboard a jazz theme cruise, which was entitled "A Tribute to Oscar Peterson" on May 31, 1995. Jazz vocalist Joe Williams conducted the interview.

JW: I am pleased indeed to be seated at the foot of the king — at the feet of the one and only Mr. Oscar Peterson. He has no idea how I feel about him, really, because I kid him, pretend that we are equals, but he's the king, really. He is the king. Oscar, this thing that we are doing, we are trying to preserve for the younger generation, some of the history of our music — how we were inspired, who inspired us, and all of that.

OP: Well speaking of the word "inspiration," I think I'm a good example of it, because I was removed from the roots of it. I came from Montreal as you know, and although it was a jazz center in Canada, it was well removed from New York, Kansas City or St. Louis or Chicago. And I had to get my background in jazz intravenously so to speak, through the radio and recordings. That was the only way I could, you know, I could ingest what was going on, was to listen to the radio at night.

JW: I did as well, you know. I heard you talking to Andre Previn. And the two of you were discussing Art Tatum, and you were telling a story I thought was marvelous, about the first time you heard him. Your father brought home recordings?

OP: Yeah. I was studying classical piano, and I was doing pretty good at it. And I was also into the jazz scene a little bit, and I was getting pretty cocky, you know, because at that time I could outplay most of my fellow students in the jazz scene. And my father sensed this, and he had a, he knew a tenor saxophone player by the name of George Sealy who had a record collection. And he showed up this day, he brought George Sealy home with him, and he said, "hey I've got something for you to hear." I said, "yeah? What is it?" He says, "it's another piano player." And I should have known better when he said "another" piano player. And he put on this record, I'll never forget the record it was "Tiger Rag" by Art. And it stopped me cold. I was decimated. I went to sleep that night, I had nightmares

of keyboards chasing me, and I really did. I dreamt all kinds of foolishness, you know, and all pertaining to the piano. The strange thing is Art wasn't in any of it. But all I knew was that I heard all these notes and I saw these keyboards coming at me. And I was so messed up, that I didn't play for a month. I didn't go near the piano for a month, you know, I didn't want any part of it. I was dejected. And then finally I started to come back and I started to get curious about how he did this, and how this man could get to these heights, and I started listening. And luckily, one good thing, as much as I have loved Art, and I say it without any remorse, one good thing is that I didn't let it overcome me. I didn't set out to do everything, or play everything that he played, the way he played it. I learned, what I learned was the, I think was the overall picture of how he looked at the piano. And it was confirmed when I had the opportunity of meeting him in person in Washington, D.C. later on.

JW: Yeah, he was one of a kind, really.

OP: That's right. Well Art was a consummate soloist. He was the epitome of a solo pianist, regardless of what medium we are talking about — jazz, classical, or what have you. And that's what he set out to do and he did that. I went the other way. I went the way of trios, because I was also a Nat Cole fan, as you know.

JW: Well you like to stomp too. I mean you like the swing and the smoke comes out, the instrument breathes, the piano breathes, and everything happens, you know. The things that I've seen you do in Chicago, in Montreal and in Toronto, you know, the things that I've seen you do, and in Hollywood — oh my God, the afternoon sessions. Basin Street. Stuff like that.

OP: Well you know, as Ray Brown said in the video of some time ago, I always believed that a group as small as a trio could stomp as hard as a big band if they were all doing the right thing. And that's the way we used to operate. You know we'd go in, I won't call any names, we went into Basin Street for instance, opposite a big band, a well known big band. And we finished our set and the leader got up on the stand and said, "we don't know what to follow that with." Because we were really stomping in our own medium. We weren't trying to do what they were doing, we were doing what we do best, in our own medium.

JW: At that time you guys did that thing better than anybody in the world, I'm telling you. And I remember seeing you at the Village Vanguard once. And I must tell this story, I don't know if I told you or not. But my wife is a very discerning person. This was in the 50's still. And she said, two things in the world that were perfect for her. One was Sam Snead's golf swing, and Ella Fitzgerald singing. And after your engagement at the Village Vanguard the second time we came to see you during that engagement, she said,

"I'm very much afraid I'm going to have to put Oscar Peterson in that category with things that are perfect." Really.

OP: Thank you.

JW: And this is from like somebody that thinks that Glenn Miller was the best thing that ever happened since sliced bread. But suddenly she rose to the occasion when you played the piano. She saw something else in the music.

OP: Well I've always had an intensity about playing piano. It's a very special experience to me. Anytime that I sit down, I was telling Benny Green, who I love, a gifted pianist as you know, and I was telling him that every time I sit down with an instrument, I try to negotiate with that instrument. He was asking me how do you handle these different pianos? Some good, some not so good, some bad, thank God we don't have too many bad ones nowadays. But I told him I says, the only way to overcome that is you have to sit down and negotiate with the instrument within the first few bars.

JW: Sure.

OP: You make a pact with the instrument that you're going to play it a certain way, and you're going to talk to it a certain way. And hopefully it will respond to you.

JW: There you go. That response is the thing, isn't it?

OP: Oh, I think so.

JW: That's what it's all about, isn't it.

OP: I think so.

JW: Oh, man, I never thought of it like that — negotiate.

OP: Well, you can't go in and fight it. You know, if you fight it you're dead.

JW: Yes.

OP: But you know that, you've seen it happen a lot of times.

JW: Yes. Going in and fighting a piano. I don't think so. Or any other instrument, really. I mean I think you have to negotiate, I mean I remember seeing Prez [Lester Young] take out a horn and say, "I'm going to have to put this girl away today, she's not ready to play." And put it away and took out another one, you know? Fun, really. But another thing that you did — when you branched out and started to do things with big orchestras, and I remember I think Ernie Wilkins did some of the work.

OP: Yes he did, he wrote an album for me.

JW: An album, yeah, yeah. And I must say, your "West Side Story" touches, I mean it's poignant when it needs to be poignant, it says so much, feeling and glory and happiness, and all the facets. You show it at the piano, and with your group, and with the people you work with.

OP: Well I have to tell you the story on "West Side Story," on that album. We had this school, the jazz school in Toronto, called The Advanced School for Contemporary Music, and it

was Ray Brown, Ed Thigpen and myself. And we were teaching there. And I got a call from Verve records and they said, "we would like you to do something on 'West Side Story.'" And I said, oh, boy, I'd heard some of the score and that's not easy, you know. So they said, "could you put something together and we'd like to do it soon, because the show is hot, and we'd like to get it out." You know like record companies, it's like do it yesterday. So while we were teaching, on off periods, I would call the group together in the school and we'd get in a room somewhere, and we'd put together arrangements on the album. We flew into New York, we arranged that we'd fly in I think it was on a Tuesday, and we said, okay there are no classes, just study periods all day Tuesday we'll be away, we'll be back Wednesday. We flew into New York and we started the session in the early afternoon, and we finished the album. We finished the album. And they didn't play back tune for tune for tune, we just came back in and listened to it. I just sat and listened to it and they ran through the album, and I said, I remember saying to Jim Davis, I said, "can we have the studio tomorrow?" He said, "I don't know, we'll get it for you if you need it," he says, "why?" I said, "I want to do the album over." He said, "well you finished the album." I said, "not really." It didn't sit right, you know, it just did not sit right. So we got together the next day and we cut the album that you are referring to, and you could obviously hear the difference between the two performances. You know there was just something not there on the first one that was there on the second. And I'm glad I did it over.

JW: Oh, yes. Tenderness, fire, and beauty. I know that the composer, Bernstein, I know he loved it. I know he loved it you know. To hear his music interpreted like that.

OP: We were almost supposed to do something with him with that. I wish we had had the chance.

JW: Well, I want to ask you about one other thing, too. I never forgot one thing. When I went in the studio in 1955 for Count Basie to record and I did "Every Day I have the Blues" and "Come Back" and the stuff that we did, Norman Granz, who sat in the control room and said, "ah, great, what else do you have for me?" That was his way of flattering me. "Oh that's marvelous, what else do you have for me?" And then he turned to me and said, "remember where you made the first one," you know. Now for me to go to Europe, I ran into some people who are here on the ship who said, "we saw you in Kurva in 1956," Sweden, it was my first trip over, and Mr. Basie has prefaced the thing by saying, "oh you've been killing them in the States, haven't you, but these people don't understand no English. Let me see what you're gonna do with that?" So we go out and we do what we do, "Every Day I Have the Blues" and that stuff, and there's about ten thousand people standing on these chairs and cheering, and I said "Bas' what are we gonna do?" He said "for once you're gonna quit while you're ahead." That was Basie, you know.

OP: That was Bas'.

JW: But that's just one instance. In 1973 now, I'm sitting in a counter in Yugoslavia. I can't even remember which city it was. Backstage. Because you know they have a place for artists to have a drink and some food backstage. But people from the theater can come back through a door and you can get into the theater through a door. And they were standing there with stacks of LP's. And I signed each one. And Norman, sitting beside me right here at the bar, and I said, "you know you are very much responsible for this, you know." Now they didn't know that I knew that between him, Voice of America and Armed Forces Radio, the stuff like that. Your experiences with him had to be —

OP: He had great insight. Norman had great insight.

JW: Norman Granz.

OP: Norman Granz had the facility to listen to various players and pair them. And in some cases pit them one against the other. You know he'd, I remember we were listening to one player, I won't call any names, we were listening to one person play and he'd say, "boy he can play. I'd like to hear him with Little Jazz" you know, Roy Eldridge.

JW: Sparks.

OP: And I'd say, "why?" I say, "why don't you just do an album with him?" He said, "we'll do one with him, but you know, I'd like to hear them get together. I'd like to see who's going to come out — there's going to be some bloodletting."

JW: There you go.

OP: He always saw it that way. And many of the great sessions were produced on that basis.

JW: Exciting. I saw Benny Carter do the same thing with Joe Newman, and Cat Anderson. You wouldn't think that that duo would do it, but it's one of the most exciting things you ever want to hear. The Japanese went crazy.

OP: That's right.

JW: You know, went absolutely crazy. Seventeen thousand of them, you know?

OP: We did, the trumpet kings, in the studio, and then he did it again in Montreux. He had Clark Terry, Dizzy, right, and Roy, and Basie's remarks that night, he was on the bill that night and Basie's remark that night before we came out was, "okay now the trumpets are up next," and Basie was sitting in a chair, you know how he'd sort of sit and overlook the whole situation, but he says [smacks his lips] "somebody's gonna get hurt tonight." He said, "somebody's gonna get it."

JW: But it made music, and some of the most exciting things that ever were played, and everybody was excited about it.

OP: That's right. Because you stretched, you know. No matter what happens, you're playing your thing, that's one thing. You're doing what you know you do and you're in that

particular sphere. But when somebody else enters your sphere of operation, then it becomes—

JW: I laugh because you told the story on yourself, somewhere I heard you telling the story on the air, you were playing and you got into some stride at the piano, and you were playing and you said you couldn't get out of it, it just came, it just happened, and you happened to look in the wings, and there was Basie going —

OP: That's right. He brought a baseball bat. We used to do this Satch and Josh thing, with the two pianos. And one night he came out on the stage and Norman said, "and on the two pianos we have Oscar Peterson and Bill Basie, would you welcome them?" I walked up from this end and Basie walked from the other. He had a baseball bat.

JW: For those of you who don't quite understand, I must explain. You see, Basie and Oscar did a thing together. And the Satch — they told this story about Satchell Paige and Josh Gibson who was the greatest hitter I guess in baseball at the time, Negro baseball. He told Satchell Paige he said, "My mother and father are coming to watch me play. And at some point, Satchell, would you please let me hit one?" You know.

OP: And so Satch said okay.

JW: He didn't say okay, he just nodded, and said hmmm, all right, it's like that. So now the game is on and Josh comes up, knocks the dust off his spikes and steps in, and looks at Satchell and Satchell shakes his head like this and — Shoooook — aspirin. Shoooook — aspirin. So probably the third time, this happened twice, the third time he came up, he say Josh knocked the dust off his cleats and looked at Satchell and [shakes head].

OP: You can't have it today.

JW: You can not hit it today. And so the idea was, Basie would look across at two pianos, and look at Oscar as if to say, "are you going to let me hit just one today? May I hit a key?" That was so, and you had to know the story.

OP: He was beautiful. But you know he had a— he did so much with the piano in doing so little as many people think, but he did a lot. Because Basie could destroy you, whatever you'd play. We played, as you'd call them "eights" — challenges — eight bars for him, eight bars for me. And I'd play my eight bars, you know, and do my thing, and Basie would come up to his eight bars and he'd go like [brief scat] and wipe me out. You know, he had that ability, because his timing was impeccable. His choice of where to put what.

JW: Did you know he used to be a drummer?

OP: I didn't know that.

JW: You didn't know that?

OP: No. I knew he played organ. I didn't know he played drums.

JW: He was a drummer once.

OP: I am not surprised.

JW: As was, you know who else — Lester Young.

OP: Lester Young was a drummer?

JW: Yeah. Lester tells a story about —

OP: I knew his brother was a drummer, Lee.

JW: He tells a story about he played drums, he says that, "By the time I got through packing up all them drums all the other ladies was gone — with all the ladies — there was no ladies left at all. The other ladies had gone then, so I got me something I could throw it in a suitcase and move real quickly."

OP: But Lester Young was also another, he was an instigator. He loved pianists. I remember there was a young man on the tour by the name of Bobby, well he's a pianist, we used to call him "Bobby Socks." And I remember we were standing backstage playing one night and Bobby says, "hey Prez, do you know this tune?" and he started to play. And Prez came up behind him, he stood there and he looked, and he said, "Bobby Socks, I see what you're doing with your right people, but what are you going to do with these left people over there that are just sitting on the piano." Because he was waiting to hear the stride left hand, you know, and he couldn't do it. But most of those guys, Ben Webster was a stride piano player.

JW: Oh yes he could play that thing. He used to love that thing. But Ben Webster, that was another case of — I think that we were so blessed to come through the time when we had those people to listen to, to appreciate, and just to make us lose ourselves in what they did. Because they were capable. Ellington — I'd get lost in his beauty, the beauty of the chords, the beauty of the way they and played together, the way they would breathe together, and the sound that they made from Otto Hardwicke to all of the guys.

OP: Johnny Hodges.

JW: Oh, Hodges, of course, you know and the baritone player, don't forget that, he was a baby when he joined the band I understand, from Boston — I can't think of his name.

OP: Harry Carney.

JW: Harry Carney, yeah. And Ben Webster when he got in there. My first record, the first record I bought was "KoKo." And the second was "Truckin.'" And then "Cottontail."

OP: Yeah, and they kept coming.

JW: Yes they did.

OP: And that band was, Louie Bellson was telling me that that band was tailored for itself. It was individual. And he said when he got in the band, he looked in the drum book and he couldn't find any parts in there. And he went to Duke and he said, "Duke, you know, how am I going to play these things." And Duke said, "well with a man with your kind of musical intelligence, it should be no problem." Duke was responsible for me doing some solo work. He said, I remember one night I'd come out, we were on the tour with him,

and he had the big band and I had the trio. And we were getting ready to leave. And he was standing in the wings with Norman Granz and myself and he said "tell me," he used to call me the Maharaja of the piano, you see, "tell me, Maharaja," he said, "have you given any thought" — I think Norman had instigated him, he was trying to get me to play solo piano, and I kept saying na, na, na, I want to play trio piano. And Duke quietly said, "have you given any thought to playing solo piano?" And I said, "no, Duke, I'm not a solo piano player, I don't do that." He said, I said, "I'm using the trio." He said, "well you know, he said, the trio is beautiful, I'm the first, you know I'm there, whenever you guys play. But" he says, "have you ever thought" and in the elegant way he'd get into it he'd say, "have you ever given any thought to the fact that people might like their caviar without the eggs and the onions?" That's the way he put it. He was something else.

JW: Very special.

OP: He was, yes. I'm thankful that I was fortunate enough to have been reared in that era, even though I was a bystander, I was a listener at the outset of it, and was fortunate enough to be able to hear all of these greats and learn from them. And that's the thing that I tell, I teach at York University in Toronto, and I tell the young players, you know they come to me with problems, I say, "go down to the record library and get this album by Johnny Hodges or this album by Ben Webster, or this album by Coleman Hawkins, or Roy Eldridge, or Dizzy, and listen to it," you know. Because that's the whole thing I think that is a detriment to the growth of jazz today, is that business, money certainly, agents and everything have intervened to the point where the youngsters heads are filled with things other than their musical things. They're filled with how many people did we get in this auditorium, how many albums can you sell, how many dates can you do in a year, and this sort of thing.

JW: Where is my monitor.

OP: That's right. And the thing is, you have to first settle, as I said, you have to first settle your thing with that instrument.

JW: Negotiate with that instrument every night. I have to negotiate with mine. Every single performance I have to negotiate, say now how we going to do this tonight?

OP: I have a thing I've had going for years and year now, when I'm on the road and I have to perform with the trio, even in nightclubs, after 5:00 at night, I don't speak to anybody. Because mentally, I'm already thinking about that gig, you know? I'm thinking of all the things that I could do tonight that I maybe perhaps did not do last night or the night before, that I should correct and do properly, and it takes that kind of thought. And that's what I tell them. I said, you know, "this is no fun and games thing, this is dedication."

JW: Many times my wife will say to me, "you didn't hear what I said, did you?" And I say, "Darling, I'm sorry I didn't hear you but I'm planning, I'm planning something, you

know, in our presentation, and consequently I didn't hear you, so please forgive me, but you have my undivided attention now if you'll repeat it." You know but you have to plan it when it comes to you to do that.

OP: That's right.

JW: When it happens. And you'd better, sometimes, write it down.

OP: That's right.

JW: Because you will forget it.

OP: I've jumped up out of bed, halfway through the night with an idea for a tune. And—

JW: About that composing that stuff, and writing, that's good, no, it's so good. You write it down.

OP: I write it down or get it down on an instrument or record it or whatever, because the next day it might not come back, it might not come back.

JW: Edward used to keep — Duke — he kept a piano beside the bed, a little, oh what are those things?

OP: Fender Rhodes?

JW: No, no not a Fender Rhodes, the other one that they used to play all the time, I've forgotten the name of them now. But he kept that little thing right beside his bed, and paper, right here by his left hand, so that he could come right out of his bed and do it, or didn't have to get out of the bed to do it.

OP: That's right.

JW: And these things that are given to us to do. I am so pleased that you are writing and I'll tell you why. Rozelle Gail, who is a good friend of Art Tatum, you know, and he used to beg Art to write. And Art he says, "I'll write it down for you, don't worry." "But you should write" [grumbles] "I don't want to write."

OP: You're caught up in the playing.

JW: But the thing is, they'll remember composers. Composers are remembered much more so than performing artists.

OP: That's right.

JW: The records won't be played, we won't hear — I haven't heard an Art Tatum recording on the radio, not even on a jazz station, in I don't know how long.

OP: I know. And it's a shame.

JW: You know, not one, man.

OP: It's a shame.

JW: And same thing with a performer like Nat King Cole. Every now and then you'll hear a Nat King Cole record. But they didn't compose anything. And I'm so pleased that you are, because that will last. Writing always lasts.

OP: Yes it does.

JW: It gets through.

OP: Yeah, it outlasts the players. Unfortunately, but it does. You know people today will recognize Tchaikovsky, they'll recognize Ellington, you know, but if you play them an Art Tatum record, they wouldn't know what you're talking about many times. Or it could be a Dizzy.

JW: And it's as fresh today as it was the date that they did it. Just as fresh. Their music today is just as fresh and beautiful and inspiring — and awe inspiring rather.

OP: The other side of that I found, you know is when I was ill a couple of years ago, and couldn't play, I turned to writing, and I found it gives you, it gave me an insight, a better insight into myself because I'd write, you know, I'd write something, then I'd go back and listen to it, take it apart and say, now why did I do that? And then I started to discover my innards, at what ticks inside of me. And you don't think of that when you're going by the notes are going by or the bars are going by like a blur, and you're busy playing, you don't think of all of that. You're thinking of what you're doing at that moment and you get up and you walk away and it's over. Not with writing. You question a lot of things when you write.

JW: Well, one thing about it, you can always do it over or you can always improve it or embellish it or add things to it or delete in case you feel it's too busy. You have all of those alternatives going for you. Listen I want to thank you for taking the time, which is our only gift, you know, the time to spend with us and this particular thing that we are doing will go in to the archives at Hamilton College, and future generations will be able to listen to it and glean from it I hope.

OP: I hope so.

JW: Yeah, I want to thank you, Oscar Peterson.

OP: You don't have to thank me, it's my pleasure.

JW: And I'm Joe Williams it says here in small fine print.